

Designing for the Indian Context

Tools for reading products, pictures, language and people's material lives, before you design for them.



Every product assumes a world.

A personal phone. Steady data. A scanner nearby. In India that world isn't the same for everyone. When it doesn't match, people build their own way around — or give up. This toolkit helps you see that gap before you design.

WITHOUT IT

“Improve the upload experience.”

WITH IT

“The upload assumes a scanner that isn't there. It costs her a cybercafé trip and a relay through her father. It's not an interface problem.”

MADE FOR

Design students

Product teams

NGO & public-service teams

Field researchers

Two ways of reading, in this edition.

Each component reads a design problem from a different side. Each works on its own. Used together, they give you a fuller picture of the person you're designing for.

1

Reading Existing Products

Whose user is built into a product, and who pays when the product is wrong about them.

MEDIA & GOSSIP

HISTORY

THE BREAK

POWER

SYNTHESIS

STARTS P.1.01 · 3-4 HOURS · CARD KIT P.1.25

4

Reading Material Reality

What people actually have around them, what it costs them, and who they lean on to get things done.

BUILD

BREAK

WEIGH

SAY

STARTS P.4.01 · 2-4 HOURS

COMING NEXT

Reading Visual Culture · Reading Language · Reflection

Just one.

Be specific. One real person, one real thing.

One real product, or one action someone had to do. Follow it from start to end, the way it actually happened. Every component in this book works on something you can point to.

WHAT COUNTS AS “ONE REAL THING”

A named product you can open, or an action with a clear start and end. It can happen on a phone, on paper, or in person.

GOOD

- ✓ Meera uploading her documents for a scholarship
- ✓ A shopkeeper paying the electricity bill
- ✓ The National Scholarship Portal

TOO BROAD

- ✗ Students using government portals
- ✗ How rural users pay bills
- ✗ Government portals

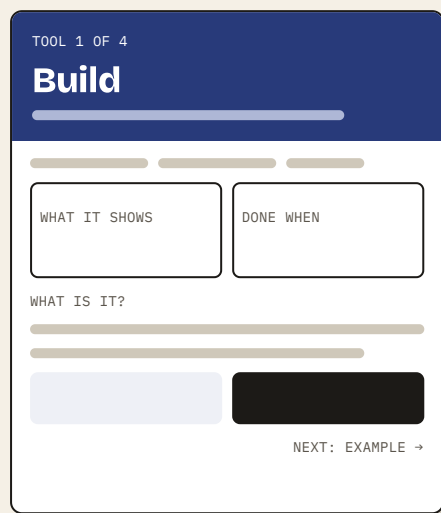
Everything else is yours to adapt: which components and tools you use, their order, the labels, the language.

How to read this toolkit

- 1 Pick a component (p.03).**
Each one works on its own. Read its opening pages first.
- 2 Pick a tool. Read its page: what it shows you, and when you're done.**
- 3 Turn the page: follow the steps on the example.**
- 4 Turn again: print the blank template and fill it for your person.**
- 5 Take what you made to the next tool, or stop there.**

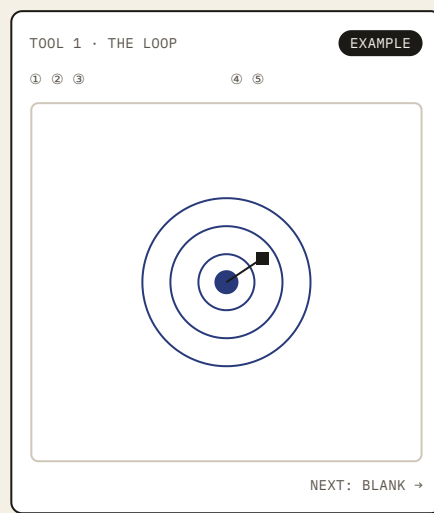
This is how every tool's pages look

Three pages, always in this order.



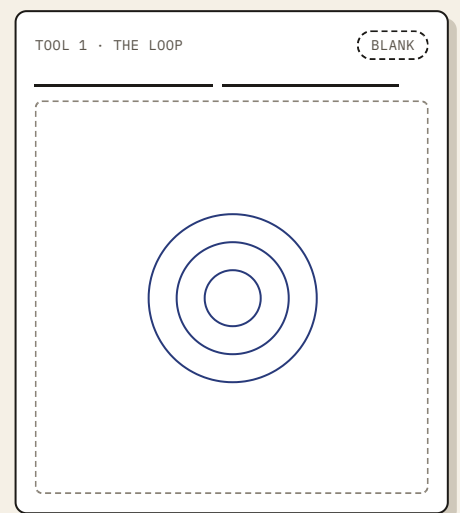
1 • The tool page

What you'll get and why



2 • The example

How to use it, shown with Meera



3 • The blank template

Print it and fill it in



Meet Meera.

Our example persona. She appears in every component.

WHO

First in her family at college

WHERE

Hostel in a Tier-2 town; family in a village

DEVICE

Her own Android phone, prepaid data

TASK

Upload documents to a national scholarship portal

THE SCREEN

“PDF only, max 200KB.”

Plus an OTP to the registered number. If it fails: an error, with no hint how to fix it.

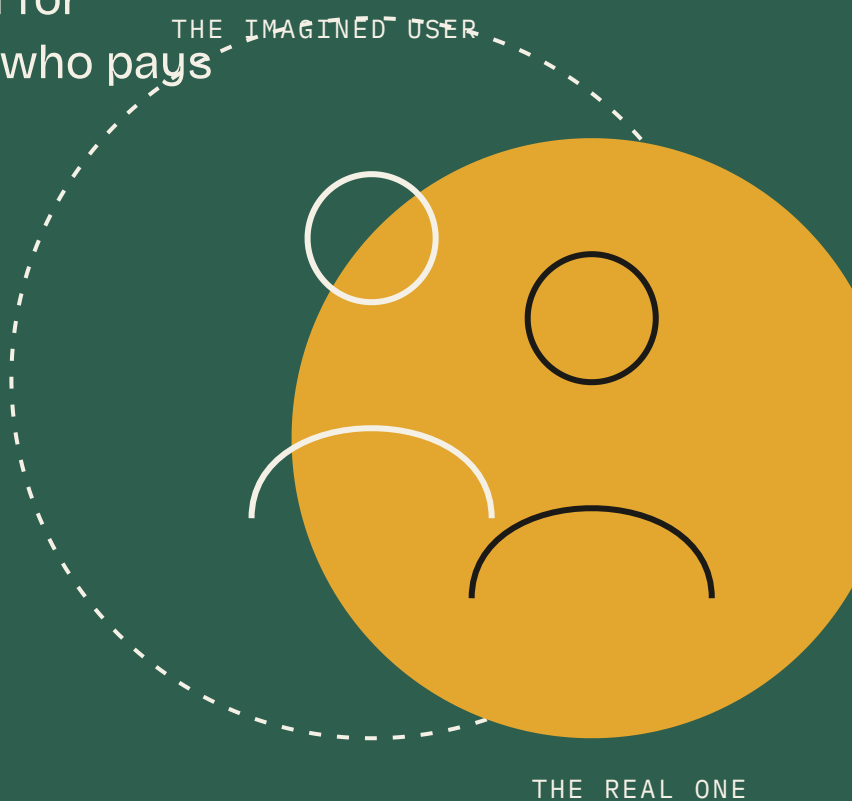
It takes her **three days**, a cybercafé, her father's phone and a family trip home. One attempt is lost when her data runs out.

Now use your own persona.

Take the persona from your project. No persona yet? Make one before you start: who they are, where they live, what phone they use, and the one thing they had to do.

Reading Existing Products

Every product was designed for someone. Find out who, and who pays when it isn't them.



4 TOOLS + SYNTHESIS

3-4 HOURS

STICKY NOTES, 3 COLOURS

OPTIONAL CARD KIT

What is this component?

Every digital product has a user built into it. Someone imagined a specific person: how much they own, how connected they are, how much time they have, who they can ask when something breaks. In most Indian public-facing products, that imagined person isn't the one actually using it.

This is not a usability audit.

It's a reading of whose assumptions are built into a product, and who pays when they're wrong.

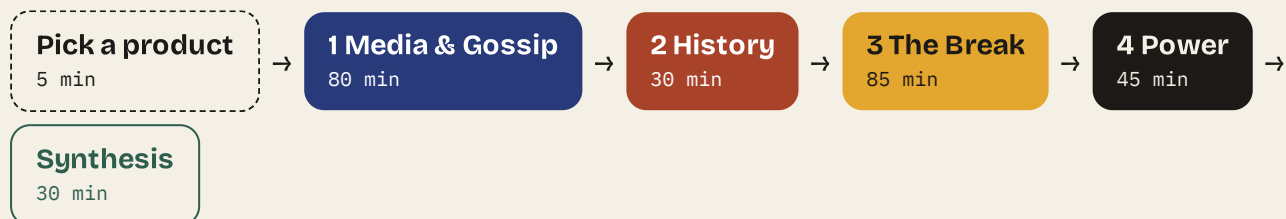
YOU NEED

The product open on your phone or laptop.
Use it for real.
A big table or wall.
3–4 hours. Tool 1 needs real research, so don't rush it.

STICKY NOTES IN THREE COLOURS

-  **Orange** · the story you're reading
-  **Yellow** · what you see and collect
-  **Teal** · what you think about it

THE ROUTE



YOU'LL END UP WITH A DESIGN CLAIM

“We should redesign ___, because it would shift blame from ___ to ___, and would specifically help ___.”

Every blank must point to a card on your table.

Two ways to use it

Every tool in this component works on paper or with cards. The questions are the same, and so is what you end up with. Pick what suits your group, or mix the two.

The paper way

Print the blank template for each tool, or copy it onto a big sheet. Write everything on sticky notes.

BEST FOR

Working alone or in pairs. A first try.
Little time.

YOU NEED

This booklet, a printer, sticky notes in three colours.

The card way

Lay a big board on the table. Printed cards hold the categories and questions. What you find goes on yellow evidence cards or sticky notes.

BEST FOR

Teams of 3–5, workshops, and sessions with participants. Cards get moved, argued over, reshuffled.

YOU NEED

The card kit: boards printed large, card sheets printed and cut (p.1.25).

WHICH PAGES FOR WHICH TOOL

TOOL	PAPER · PRINT THESE	CARD KIT · BOARD + CARDS
 Media & Gossip	1.07 · 1.09	B1, B2 · S1, S2
 History	1.12	B3 · S1, S3
 The Break	1.15 · 1.16 · 1.18	B4, B5 · S1, S4, S5, S6
 Power	1.21	B6 · S1, S3, S7
 Synthesis	1.23	B7 · S8

Either way, read the tool page and the example first. Using the kit? On example pages, a green tag like  shows which card goes where, and  tells you which board to lay out.

NEXT PAGE **Pick one product →**

Pick one product.

One specific product that your users actually use. Not a category. You should be able to open it and use it while you answer every question.

A PRODUCT

✓ National Scholarship Portal

✓ DigiLocker

✓ Google Maps

TOO BROAD

✗ Government scholarship portals

✗ Document apps

✗ Navigation apps

OUR PRODUCT

**National
Scholarship
Portal**

Write its full name on an orange note.

Stick it at the top of your table. Everything until Synthesis is about this one product. In Tool 3 you'll narrow it down further, to one feature.

Our running example uses the National Scholarship Portal and Meera. The filled examples are illustrative. Your own tables must use real ads, real reviews and real quotes.

Media & Gossip

What does it promise, and what do people actually say?

⌚ 80 MIN SOLO OR PAIR EFFORT ●●● DESK + ONLINE RESEARCH

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

The story the product sells, the story its users live, and where the two contradict each other.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The Venn is filled with real quotes and you've named the hardest contradiction.

WHAT IS IT?

Two readings. First, study the product's ads and official messages, and compare the person in them with your real user. Then collect what people say about the product in three places and lay them side by side, to see what never gets said officially.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Media story	How the product presents itself: ads, app store page, scheme notices.
Official feedback	Reviews, FAQs and support replies the company controls.
Gossip	What users tell each other, away from the company.
Contradiction	Where two of these directly disagree.

WHERE TO FIND GOSSIP

[Reddit](#)[Quora](#)[YouTube comments](#)[WhatsApp forwards](#)[X / Twitter](#)[Regional Facebook groups](#)[Your interviews](#)

YOU NEED

Real ads and notices, and 60 minutes of real research. Never invent a quote.

YOU'LL END UP WITH

The product's imagined user, and the hardest contradiction, for Synthesis

CARD KIT Boards B1, B2 · Cards S1, S2 · p.134

NEXT PAGE **Example · Media Story** →

The Media Story

EXAMPLE

THE PERSON IN THE ADS

B1 • SCREENSHOT

Smiling student, own laptop, bright desk, finishes in one sitting.

THE REAL USER

B1 • PHOTO

Meera, 19. Phone at 12% in a hostel corridor. Worried. Three days, several tries.

A • What it claims

S1 EVIDENCE

MAIN PROMISE

"One place for all scholarships."

WORD IT NEVER DELIVERS

"Seamless"

USERS' OWN TAGLINE

"Upload karo, reject ho jao, phir se karo."

B • The story it sells

S1 EVIDENCE

PROMISES TO FIX

The distance between students and money they're owed.

JOURNEY IN ITS STORY

Starts at log-in. Ends at "Submitted".

LEFT OUT OF THE STORY

Getting documents, the cybercafé, the months of waiting.

C • What the designers meant

IN THEIR WORDS

"Let students apply for every scholarship on one platform."

WHO THEY IMAGINED

Own laptop, scanner, broadband, a parent who knows forms.

DESIGNED AGAINST

Fraud. Cost: heavy document checks for everyone.

D • How the user sees it

TOOL OR GATE?

A gate she has to get through.

WHAT SHE CALLS IT

"Woh NSP wala form"

WHAT SHE THINKS HAPPENS NEXT

"Someone reads it." In fact: automatic checks, then her college verifies.

Illustrative example. On your table, copy real ads and real words.

CARD KIT Board B1 • p.134

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Spend 15 minutes with real ads and notices.

2

Describe the person in the ads, then your real user.

3

Fill A and B on yellow notes: what it claims and sells.

4

Fill C and D on teal notes: what designers meant, how users see it.

5

Keep the four groups on the table for Part B.

The Media Story

BLANK TEMPLATE

PRODUCT

THE PERSON IN THE ADS • AGE, PLACE, DEVICE,
FACE

YOUR REAL USER • SAME DETAILS

A • What it claims

Its main promise, in its own words

The word it repeats but never delivers

A tagline your users would write

B • The story it sells

What it promises to fix but can't

Where its journey starts and ends

What its story leaves out

C • What the designers meant

The problem, in their words

The user they imagined

What they designed against, and its cost

D • How the user sees it

A tool, or a gate to get through?

What they call it

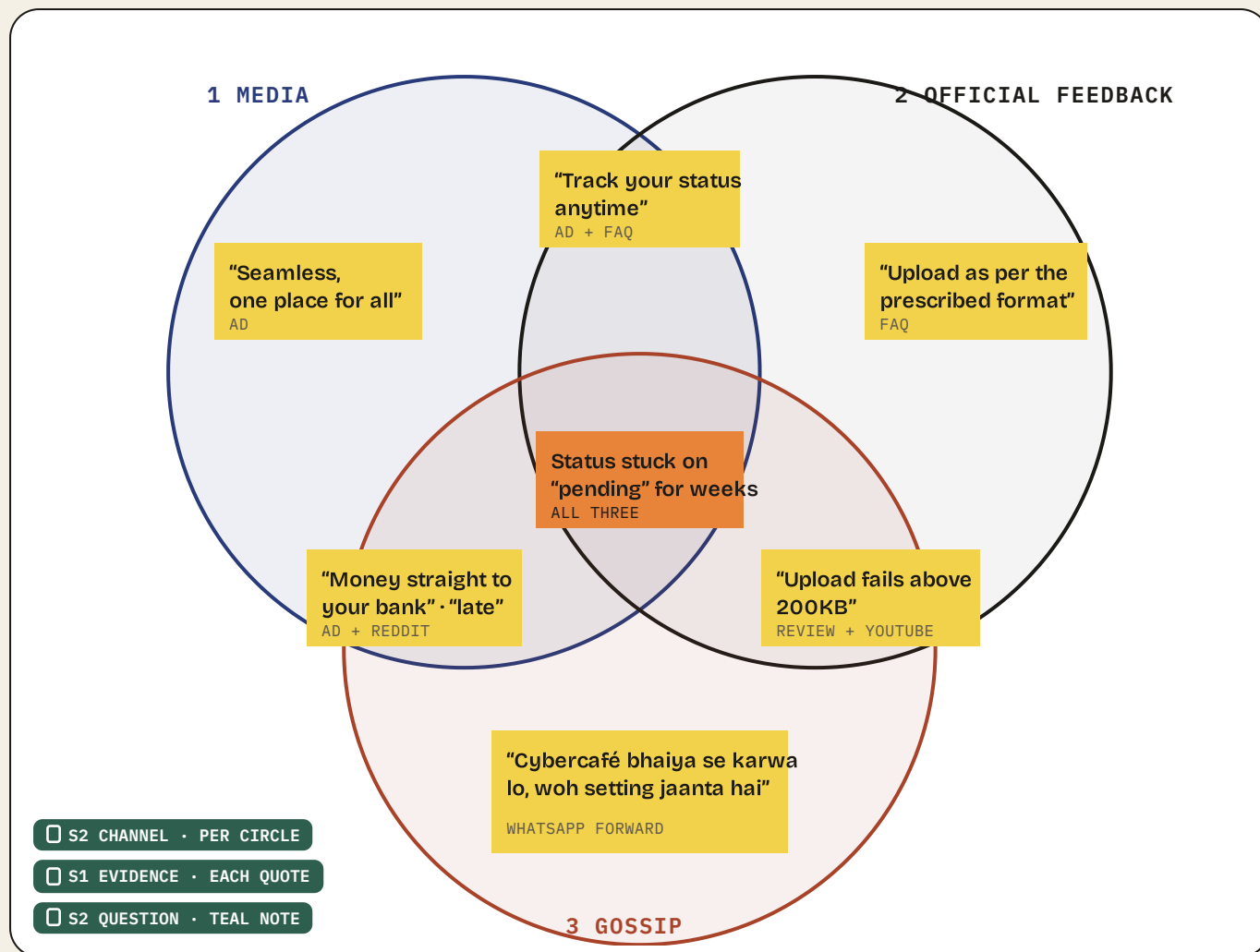
What they think happens after they submit

CARD KIT Board B1 • p.134

NEXT **Part B • The Gossip Venn →**

The Gossip Venn

EXAMPLE



HARDEST CONTRADICTION

☐ B2 • SLOT

Media says "track your status anytime". Gossip says nobody can tell you where your application is. Set this card aside for Synthesis.

Illustrative example. Use only real quotes you find, and write the channel under each.

CARD KIT Board B2 • p.135

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Move your Part A notes into circle 1.

2

Collect official feedback: reviews, FAQs, support replies.

3

Find real gossip. Note the channel on each quote.

4

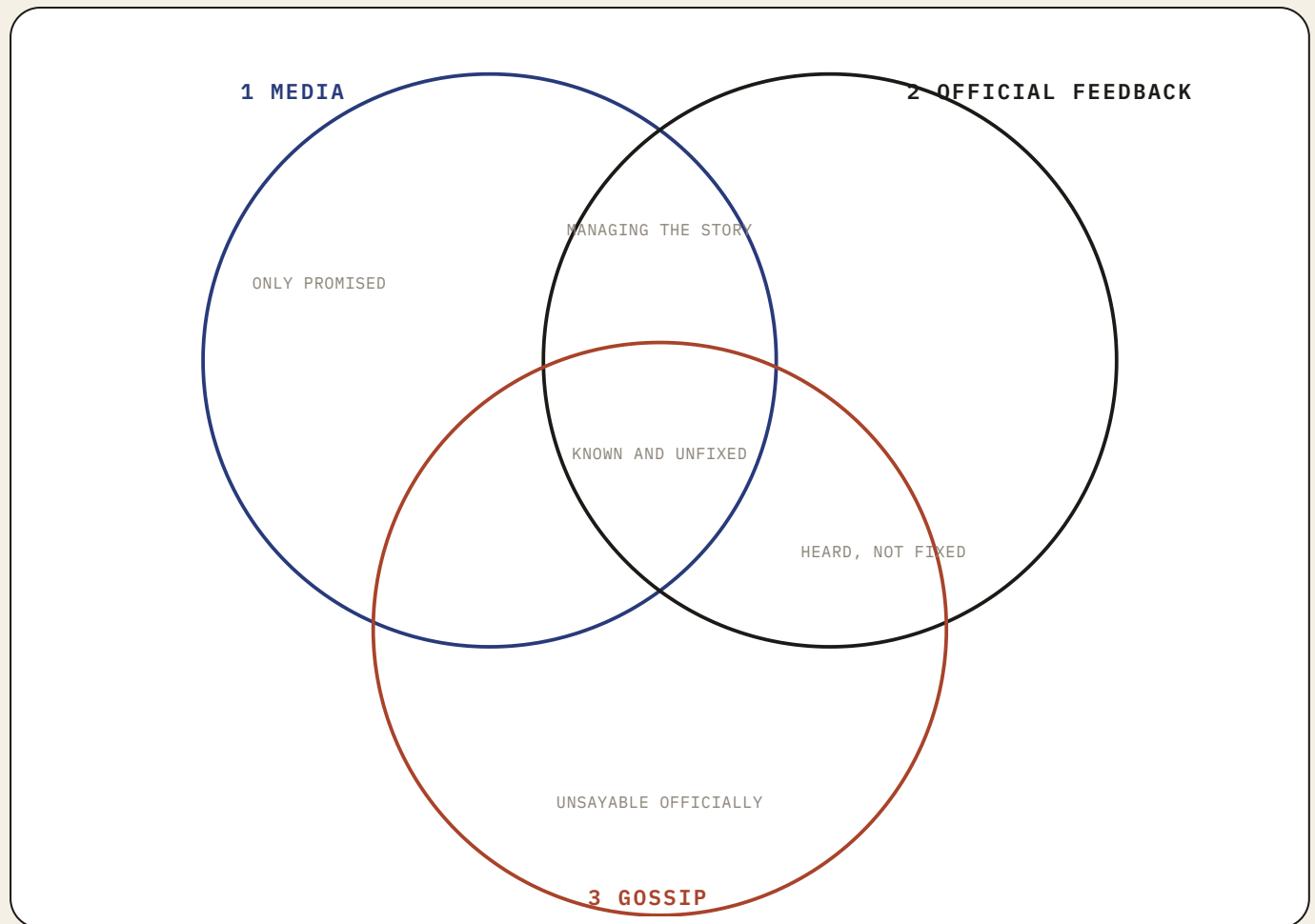
Place each quote in its zone. Overlaps matter most.

5

Name the hardest contradiction.

The Gossip Venn

BLANK TEMPLATE


☐ **Gossip only.** Why can't this be said officially?

☐ **Centre.** Why hasn't it been fixed? Who gains?

☐ **Folk fixes.** What workaround do seniors pass on?

☐ **Media only.** Aspiration, or misleading?

☐ **Tone.** Which words vanish in official channels?

☐ **Hardest contradiction.** Which two circles clash most?

HARDEST CONTRADICTION • KEEP FOR SYNTHESIS

CARD KIT Board B2 • p.135

NEXT **Tool 2 • History** →

History

What was here before, and what got lost?

🕒 30 MIN WITH SOMEONE OLDER, IF YOU CAN EFFORT ●●○ FIELD OR DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

What the product replaced, who lost or gained a role, and whether people shape the product or it shapes them.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Your timeline has Then, Recently and Now, and both arrows have at least one note.

WHAT IS IT?

Look backwards only. Find out how this was done before it went digital: who did what, where, and who was in the room. The best way is a 20-minute talk with someone who did it the old way: a parent, a teacher, a clerk.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Then · Recently · Now Three points on a timeline of how this was done.

People → product Ways users bent the product to fit them.

Product → people Ways the product forced new habits on users.

YOU NEED

Someone older to talk to. If not, old circulars, archived pages or news from the launch.

YOU'LL END UP WITH

What the product removed, and whose power stayed the same

CARD KIT Board B3 · Cards S1, S3 · p.136

NEXT PAGE **Example · The timeline →**

The timeline

EXAMPLE

S1 EVIDENCE • ON THE TIMELINE

Then

Paper form from school.
Principal signs. Father takes it to the district office. A clerk checks it, and you can explain your case.

Recently

Apply online, then hand a printed copy and documents to the college.

Now

Fully online. OTP to a registered phone. The college verifies on the portal.

PEOPLE → PRODUCT

Seniors share the cybercafé's "setting" for getting PDFs under 200KB.

PRODUCT → PEOPLE

Everyone now needs a PDF, an OTP number and an email address.

WHAT IT REMOVED

S3 QUESTION

Pleading your case to a person who could bend a rule.

SAME POWER, NEW MEDIUM

S3 QUESTION

The principal's signature became the college's online verification.

WHO SHAPES WHOM

Product → people is much stronger.

S3 PEOPLE

Lost a role: the clerk who could explain and make exceptions.

S3 PEOPLE

Gained one: cybercafé operators and form-filling agents.

Illustrative example. Build yours from a real conversation or real archives.

CARD KIT Board B3 • p.136

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Talk to someone who did it before it went digital.

2

Write Then, Recently and Now on the timeline.

3

Note who lost a role and who gained one.

4

Put each change on its arrow.

5

Answer the three teal questions.

The timeline

BLANK TEMPLATE

Then
Who did what, where? Who was in the room?

Recently
What changed first?

Now
How it works today.

PEOPLE → PRODUCT

A workaround users created that the product now depends on

PRODUCT → PEOPLE

A habit or skill the product forced on users

Who lost a role?

Who gained one?

What did it remove that people used to be able to do?

Which power relationship stayed the same, in a new form?

Which arrow is stronger?

CARD KIT Board B3 • p.136

NEXT **Tool 3 • The Break →**

The Break

Where does the ideal story break, and who gets blamed?

🕒 85 MIN SOLO OR PAIR EFFORT ●●● DESK, WITH FIELD NOTES

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

What each step quietly expects the user to have, where it breaks for a real person, and who gets blamed.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every step has its four needs, a persona has walked the flow, and the likeliest break is starred.

WHAT IS IT?

Pick the product's core feature. Map it the way the designer imagined: everything works. Under each step, list what it silently needs. Then walk someone very unlike the imagined user through it, and see where it breaks and who gets blamed.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Ideal flow	The steps as the designer pictured them. The fantasy version.
Requirements	What each step needs: people, objects, systems, information.
Blame scale	A line from “my fault” to “the system's fault”.
Villain	A persona unlike the ideal user, walked through the flow to break it.

Remember: in India the “edge case” is often the majority. Someone decided to call them an edge case.

YOU NEED

The product open, and your field notes on real failures

YOU'LL END UP WITH

The likeliest break, and the blame gap, for Synthesis

CARD KIT Boards B4, B5 · Cards S1, S4–S6 · p.137

NEXT PAGE **Example · Ideal flow →**

Ideal flow + what each step needs

EXAMPLE

FEATURE	Upload documents & submit						GOAL	"Application submitted, confirmation received."					
	1	2	3	4	5	6							
	Logs in with mobile	Fills in details	Uploads marksheet PDF	Enters OTP	Submits	Gets confirmation							
PEOPLE	—	Parent, for income details	Cybercafé owner	Father, whose phone it is	—	—							
OBJECTS	Own phone number	Aadhaar, bank passbook	Scanner, PDF	The registered phone	Data pack	Email account							
SYSTEMS	SMS gateway	Aadhaar match	Portal upload	SMS on time	Server up	College verifies							
INFORMATION	Which number is registered	Name spelled exactly as on Aadhaar	Files must be under 200KB	OTP expires in minutes	Deadline is midnight	Must chase the college							

● Left as the user's problem to solve: 13 of 24.

□ S4 NEED CARD PER CELL • FILL ITS DOT

WHO THIS WAS DESIGNED FOR

Their own laptop and phone. A scanner at home. Broadband. An uninterrupted hour. A parent who knows forms.

Illustrative example.

CARD KIT Board B4 • p.1.37

How to use it

1

Pick the core feature. Write its goal.

2

List each step as a short verb, the way it's meant to go.

3

Describe who this was designed for.

4

Under each step, write the people, objects, systems and info it needs.

5

Dot every need left for the user to solve.

Next page • Blank template →

Ideal flow + what each step needs

BLANK TEMPLATE

FEATURE	GOAL					
STEPS	1	2	3	4	5	6
PEOPLE who must help?						
OBJECTS what must they own?						
SYSTEMS what else must work?						
INFORMATION what must they already know?						

Put a dot on every need the designers left for the user to solve.

WHO THIS WAS DESIGNED FOR • DEVICE, TIME, SKILLS, WHO THEY CAN CALL

CARD KIT Board B4 • p.137

NEXT **Part B • The Blame Scale** →

The Blame Scale

EXAMPLE ABOVE • BLANK BELOW

Step 3 fails: the upload is rejected.

S5 BLAME TOKENS 1 • 2 • ★

EXAMPLE

Meera: "PDF kaise banate hain, mujhe hi nahi pata tha"



1 • Where she puts it. On herself.

2 • What the product implies.

"Please upload in the prescribed format": her fault.

★ Where it belongs. The

Requirements Map: no way to make a PDF on a phone.

The gap is the distance between what this product **punishes** and what it should have **designed for**.

Step that fails: _____

BLANK

Self

System

1 What the user says, in their words

2 What the product's error or FAQ implies

★ Where your Requirements Map says it belongs

The gap is the distance between what this product _____ and what it should have _____.

How to use it

CARD KIT Board B5, bottom strip • p.138

1

Pick a step that fails. Use real field quotes.

2

Place token 1 where the user puts the blame.

3

Place token 2 where the product's words put it.

4

Write the gap sentence. Keep it for Synthesis.

The Villain Story

EXAMPLE

PERSONA

S6 CONSTRAINT

Meera, 19
Hostel, Tier-2 town. Applying on her phone.

One constraint: the registered phone is her father's.

S5 FAILURE

FIVE FAILURE CARDS • CHOOSE THE LIKELIEST AT EACH STEP

- System failure
- Person unavailable
- Object missing
- Information gap
- No time

STEP	CARD DRAWN	WHAT BROKE • WORKAROUND	HOW LIKELY	WHO PAYS
★ 3 Upload	Object missing	No scanner, no PDF. Pays a cybercafé.	8 / 10	Meera: ₹30–50, half a day
4 OTP	Person unavailable	Father is in the field. OTP expires; she retries at night.	7 / 10	Meera: a day. Father: his work.
2 Details	Information gap	Name spelled differently on marksheet and Aadhaar. An agent “fixes” it.	6 / 10	₹200, and her data with a stranger
5 Submit	No time	Exam week. Session times out while she finds the certificate.	5 / 10	Starts over, progress lost

DOES SHE KNOW SHE'S THE EXCEPTION?

S5 QUESTION

No. Every error says the problem is her document.

IS THE WORKAROUND DIGNIFIED?

S5 QUESTION

Not really. She shares private details with an agent she doesn't know.

Illustrative example.

CARD KIT Board B5 • p.138

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Make a persona unlike the ideal user, with one hard constraint.

2

Walk them through each step of your flow.

3

At each step, choose the likeliest failure card.

4

Write the workaround, how likely it is, and who pays.

5

Star the likeliest break.

The Villain Story

BLANK TEMPLATE

PERSONA

NAME _____ CONTEXT _____

THE ONE CONSTRAINT _____

STEP	CARD DRAWN	WHAT BROKE • WORKAROUND	HOW LIKELY	WHO PAYS
			-- / 10	
			-- / 10	
			-- / 10	
			-- / 10	
			-- / 10	

Star the likeliest break. Clip each workaround to the requirement it stands in for.

THE FIVE FAILURE CARDS • CUT OUT

System failure

Something in the Systems row doesn't work.

Person unavailable

Someone from the People row isn't there.

Object missing

Something from the Objects row isn't at hand.

Information gap

They don't know it, and the product doesn't say.

No time

Everything's there, but not the time it demands.

CARD KIT Board B5 • p.138

NEXT **Tool 4 • Power →**

Power

What does this product do to power?

⌚ 45 MIN SOLO OR PAIR EFFORT ●●● DESK + ONLINE RESEARCH

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Who built it and under what pressure, what the institution really protects, and whose unpaid work keeps it running.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

All three lenses are answered and every finding is rated minor, major or critical.

WHAT IS IT?

Zoom out from one user to everyone the product touches: the institution, the company that built it, the teacher, the sibling, the agent. Read it through three lenses. Look at what it actually does, not what it says it intends.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Creator lens	Who built it, and what they were rushing or saving on.
Authority lens	What the institution is really guarding against.
Political lens	Does it make people more independent, or more dependent?
Invisible labour	Unpaid or unseen work by people who aren't the user.

YOU NEED

Tender documents or press about who built it, the grievance page, and your notes from Tools 1–3

YOU'LL END UP WITH

A findings sheet, rated, for Synthesis

CARD KIT Board B6 • Cards S1, S3, S7 • p.139

NEXT PAGE **Example • Three lenses →**

Three lenses + findings

EXAMPLE

Creator

S7 LENS

Built to a desktop checklist. No screen that says “upload worked”. Errors written for engineers: “File size exceeds limit.”

Authority

S7 LENS

Most friction sits at document checks: it guards against fraud, not against students failing. Complaints go to an email form with no timeline.

Political

S7 LENS

Students end up more dependent on helpers, not less. It asks for income, bank and identity details before giving anything back.

Invisible labour

S3 PEOPLE · TICK EACH CARD

IS IT...

WHO	SEEN?	PAID?	LOAD-BEARING?
Cybercafé owner	×	By the student	Yes
Father, who holds the phone	×	×	Yes
College admin, now tech support	×	×	Yes
Form-filling agent	×	By the student	Partly

Findings sheet

S7 FINDING · PLACE BY SEVERITY

FRICITION USERS HIT

TENSIONS INSIDE THE SYSTEM

OTP goes to someone else's phone	CRITICAL	Built for fraud checks, not completion	CRITICAL
No way to make a PDF on a phone	CRITICAL	Grievance path has no timeline	MAJOR
Status stuck on “pending”	MAJOR	Errors written for engineers	MINOR

Illustrative example. Check who built your product and how its grievance path works before writing.

CARD KIT Board B6 · p.139

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Choose: this product live, or 2–3 similar ones.

2

Creator: who built it, and what did they rush?

3

Authority: where's the friction? Whom does it protect?

4

Political: whose unpaid work keeps it running?

5

Fill the findings sheet. Rate each one.

Three lenses + findings

BLANK TEMPLATE

Creator

Who built it? Were they rushing, saving money or ticking boxes? Find three moments where it shows.

Authority

Where is the most friction? Whom does it protect? How many steps to reach a human? Whose name is in the error?

Political

More independent or more dependent? What must users hand over? Where does their data go? What would it have to stop doing?

Invisible labour			
WHO	SEEN?	PAID?	LOAD-BEARING?

Findings sheet

FRICION USERS HIT

minor · major · critical

minor · major · critical

minor · major · critical

minor · major · critical

TENSIONS INSIDE THE SYSTEM

minor · major · critical

minor · major · critical

minor · major · critical

minor · major · critical

CARD KIT Board B6 · p.139

NEXT **Synthesis** →

Synthesis

EXAMPLE

Pull every story card back onto the table. Make them compete until one direction survives. Every answer must point to a card.

1 One line from each tool □ S8 ONE LINE × 5

MEDIA	Promises “one place, seamless”.
GOSSIP	Nobody can tell you where your application is.
HISTORY	You can no longer plead your case to a person.
POWER	It only works because of unpaid helpers.
VILLAIN *	No way to make a PDF on a phone (8/10).

2 The sharpest contradiction

“The product claims to be one seamless place, but the Villain Story revealed it needs a scanner, a cybercafé and a father's phone.”

3 Three candidate redesigns □ S8 REDESIGN A • B • C

A Photo-to-PDF inside the upload step

B An error that says how to fix the file

C OTP to a number the student chooses

4 Test on the Blame Scale □ B7 • LAY A B C ON THE LINE

A moves the blame furthest toward the system. C moves it some. B only explains the failure, so it's set aside.

5 Test on Power

“If A were built, students without scanners would gain a free way to submit. Cybercafés and agents would resist it, because they'd lose paid work.”

6 The finding

“This product assumes a scanner and a PDF, but the user actually has a phone camera, which causes a paid trip, a lost day and self-blame.”

7 The design claim □ S8 CLAIM

“We should redesign **the document upload step**, because it would shift blame from “mujhe hi nahi pata tha” to the portal's missing PDF path, and would specifically help Meera, and students like her with only a phone.”

Illustrative example.

CARD KIT Board B7 • p.1.40

NEXT PAGE **Blank template →**

Synthesis

BLANK TEMPLATE

1 One line from each tool

MEDIA

GOSSIP

HISTORY

POWER

VILLAIN ★

2 The sharpest contradiction

"The product claims _____, but _____ revealed
_____."

3 Three candidate redesigns • specific screens or steps, from your cards

4 Blame Scale test • which one moves the blame toward the system most?

5 Power test

"If this were built, _____ would gain _____. And _____ would
resist it because _____."

6 The finding

"This product assumes _____, but the user actually has _____, which
causes _____."

7 The design claim

"We should redesign _____, because it would shift blame from
_____ to _____, and would specifically help _____."

CARD KIT Board B7 • p.140

NEXT Is it working? →

Is it working?

GOOD SIGNS

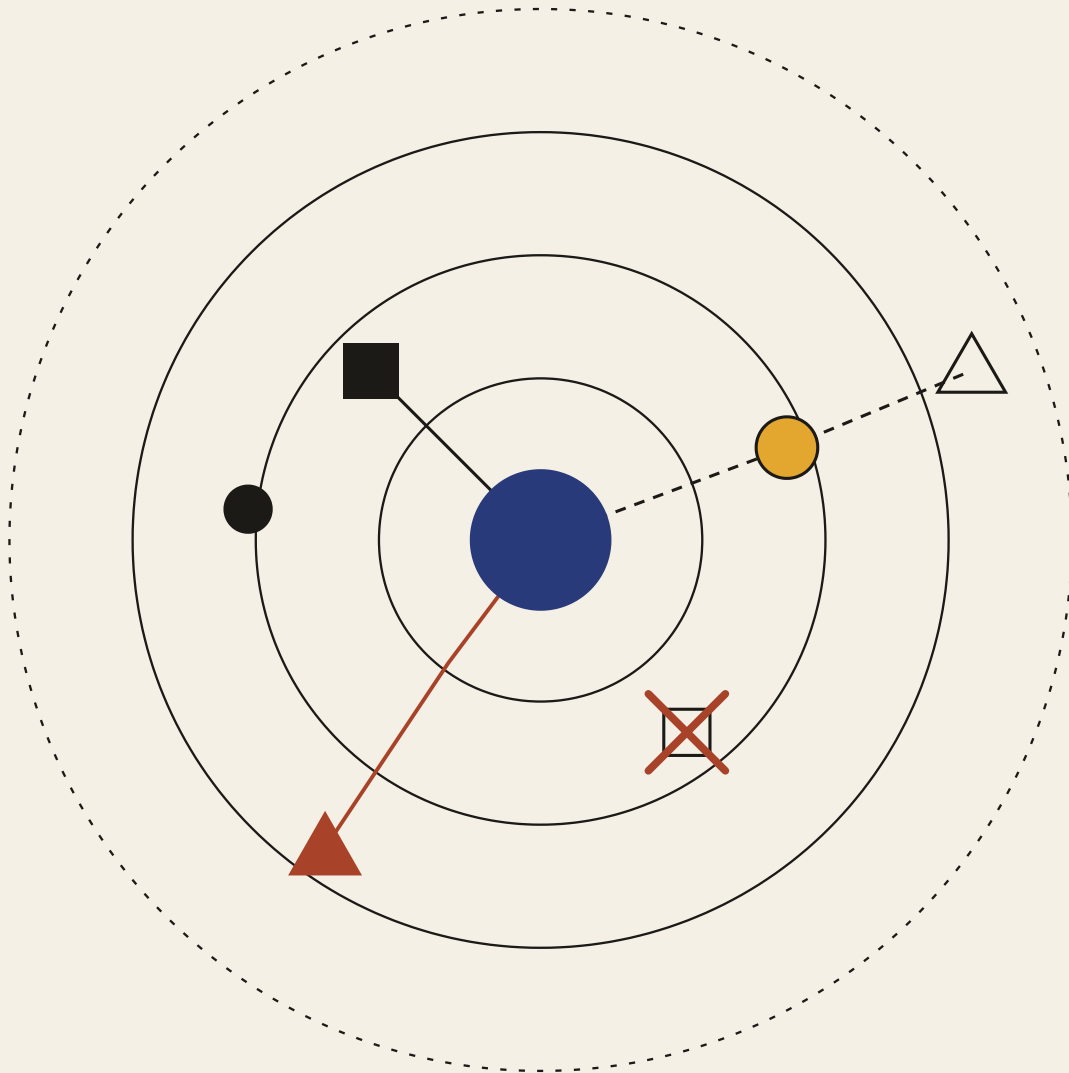
- ✓ The hardest contradiction in the Venn surprises you.
- ✓ The Requirements Map makes you uneasy about assumptions you'd have made yourself.
- ✓ Your villain persona turns out to be common, not rare.
- ✓ The two blame tokens are far apart.
- ✓ You name people the product has never named.

WARNING SIGNS, AND WHAT TO DO

- ✗ All three Venn circles say the same thing.
Research deeper, or pick a product people actually talk about.
- ✗ Your villain is just the ideal user with one inconvenience.
Pick a harder constraint: a shared phone, a missing document, a passed deadline.
- ✗ "Specifically help ____" names a category, not a person.
Go back to the invisible labour table and name one person.
- ✗ You can fill the design claim without looking at your cards.
It's coming from your head, not the evidence. Go back to the table.

Material Reality

Practical tools to see what people actually have, what it costs them, and who they lean on — before you design for them.



4 TOOLS

1 GUIDELINE

1 MAP

SCOLARSHIP PORTAL

What is material reality?

Everything around a screen that a person needs to get something done.
The phone, the data, the papers, the places, the people who help.
Products quietly assume all of it is there.

A "SIMPLE" UPLOAD ACTUALLY NEEDED

a charged phone

steady Wi-Fi

a scanner

knowing what a PDF is

the income certificate

₹50

her father's phone

WHAT TO LOOK FOR • NINE LAYERS



Devices

Whose phone, how old, how much space



Connection

Data, Wi-Fi, signal, recharges



Power

Battery, charging, power cuts



Places

Cybercafé, office, bank, home



Papers

Certificates, IDs, printouts



Money

What each step costs, and what it pushes aside



People

Who helps, who holds the phone, who knows how



Know-how

Knowing what an OTP or PDF is, in which language



Time & privacy

A quiet hour, a private corner

LOOK PAST

Do they have it?

TO

Can they really use it?

AND

Who and what do they lean on?

I want to...

Find what you need, go to that tool. Every tool works on its own. Used in order, they build one picture.

...see what my user's world actually holds

TOOL 1 · BUILD

p.4.06

...find where access breaks

TOOL 1 · BUILD

p.4.09

...see who people depend on to get it done

TOOL 2 · BREAK

p.4.11

...understand why people drop off

TOOL 2 · BREAK

p.4.14

...know what gets compromised in their lives

TOOL 3 · WEIGH

p.4.16

...turn findings into a clear problem

TOOL 4 · SAY

p.4.19

...OR RUN THEM ALL, IN ORDER

Visual Toolkit
photos + lenses



1 Build



2 Break



3 Weigh



4 Say

QUICK · ABOUT AN HOUR

**Tool 1 → Tool 2 → a three-line
brief**

DEEP · A FIELD VISIT

All four, with participants

First, map the journey.

Tool 1 asks what a person uses at each step. You can only answer that once you know the steps. So write them down first.

ALREADY HAVE ONE?

Use your journey map or service blueprint. Need a refresher?

[Journey mapping 101 · NN/g](#)

[Service blueprints · NN/g](#)

Experience Map & Blueprint · Nesta DIY Toolkit

NEW TO THIS?

Use the Journey Strip below. For each step, write **where** they are and **what or who** they use. Nothing else.

Journey Strip · Meera

EXAMPLE

STEP	1 Sees the notice	2 Opens the portal	3 Makes the PDF	4 Gets the certificate	5 Enters the OTP	6 Uploads
WHERE	Hostel	Hostel room	Cybercafé	Home village	Hostel	Hostel
USES · WHO HELPS	Class WhatsApp, her phone	Phone, hostel Wi-Fi	₹50, the owner	Father, Tehsildar office	Father's phone	Data pack

Every item in the bottom row becomes something you place on the Loop in Tool 1.

Journey Strip · your person

BLANK

STEP	1	2	3	4	5	6
WHERE						
USES · WHO HELPS						

From the Visual Toolkit, bring these.

In the Visual Toolkit, participants photograph and film their surroundings and tag each picture with a lens. Those tagged pictures, and the inferences you drew from them, are what Tool 1 builds on.

1

Collect the photos, videos and lens tags.

2

Sort each one: person ●, thing ■ or place ▲.

3

Note how easy it is to reach: in hand, where they live, a trip away, or through someone.

4

Print them small. Bring them to the Loop with your Journey Strip.

FILLED EXAMPLE · MEERA'S PHOTOS, SORTED

P1  Wi-Fi router in the hostel corridor LENS: SHARED ■ WHERE SHE LIVES	P2  Cybercafé signboard near the bus stand LENS: WORKAROUND ▲ A TRIP AWAY	P3  Father's phone on the shelf at home (sent by family) LENS: SHARED ■ THROUGH SOMEONE
P4  Her phone at 12% battery, data almost used up LENS: ACCESS ■ IN HAND	P5  Video: queue outside the Tehsildar office LENS: MISSING ▲ THROUGH SOMEONE	P6  Senior's room — "he knows everything" LENS: WORKAROUND ● A TRIP AWAY

Lens names above are placeholders. Use the lenses from your Visual Toolkit.

ALSO BRING YOUR INFERENCES

Turn each one into a question for the Ladder. "The router is shared by 40 rooms" becomes: **does Wi-Fi keep working when she needs it?**

NO VISUAL TOOLKIT?

Tool 1 still works. Ask the person to walk you through the task and sketch what they point to.

Build

What does the task need, and where does it stop working?

⌚ 45 MIN 👤 SOLO OR WITH PARTICIPANT EFFORT ●●○ 📍 DESK OR FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Everything the task depends on, how easy each thing is to reach, and where each one stops working.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every step of the journey has something on the map, and every key item is checked on the ladder.

WHAT IS IT?

Two sheets. On the **Loop**, you place everything the task needs around the person. The easier something is to get to, the closer it sits. On the **Ladder**, you take the most important items and ask seven simple questions about each, to find where it fails.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE



Loop

A map of rings around the person. Inner rings are easier to reach.



Token

A sticker for a person ●, a thing ■ or a place ▲.



Line

One small action, like “borrows” or “pays for”.



Ladder

Seven yes/no questions, from “Does it exist?” to “Are they allowed to use it?”

YOU NEED

Your Journey Strip (p.4.04) and Visual Toolkit photos (p.4.05)

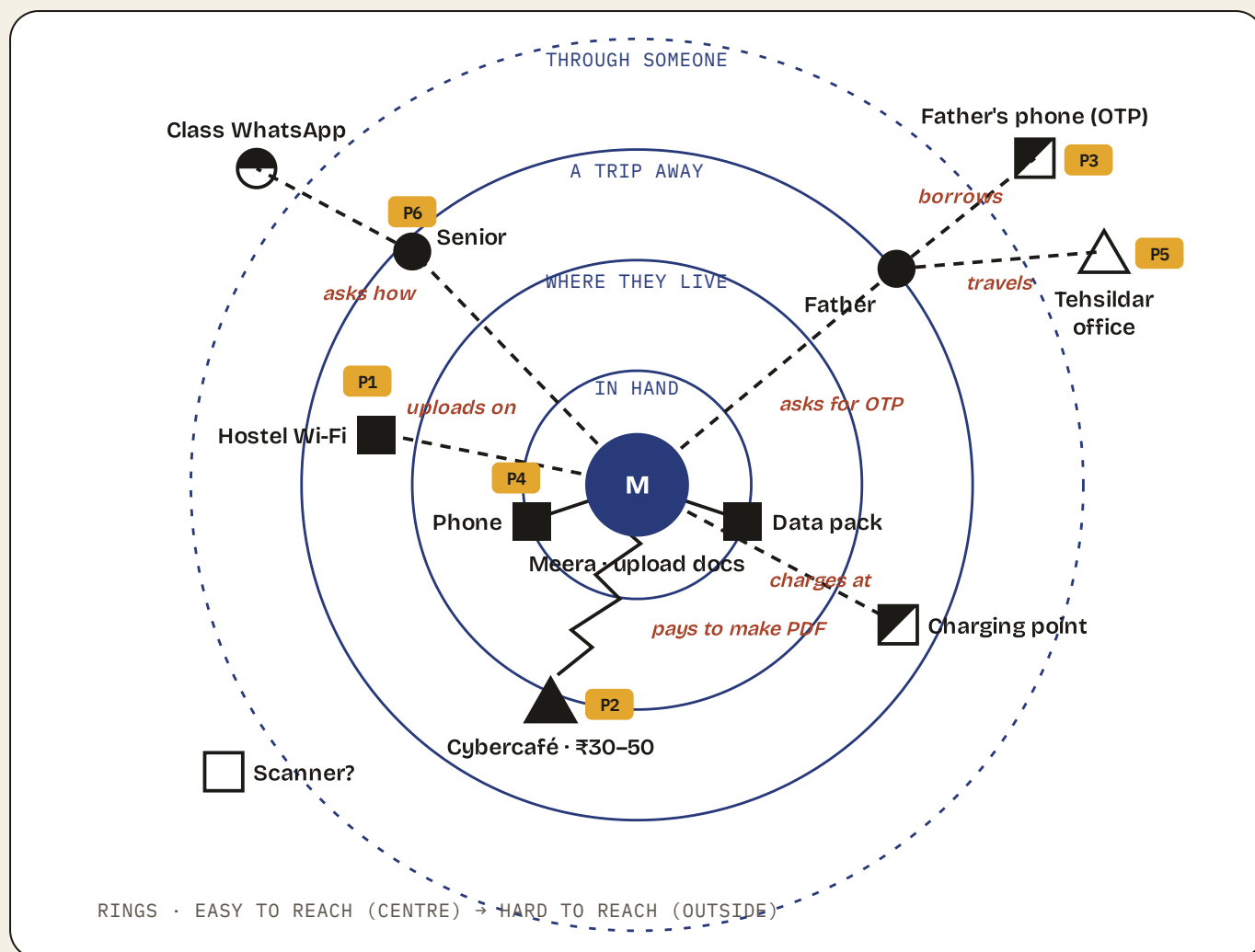
YOU'LL END UP WITH

A map of what the task needs, and where it breaks. Take the breaks to Tool 2.

NEXT PAGE **Example • The Loop →**

The Loop

EXAMPLE



● ■ ▲ person · thing · place ■ photo - - - line = one action, *verb* on it
 solid / half / outline = seen / told / assumed

How to use it

[Next page · Blank template →](#)

1

Write the person and the task in the centre.

2

Add a token for each thing they used.

3

Put it on the ring for how easy it is to reach.

4

Draw a line for each action. Write the verb on it.

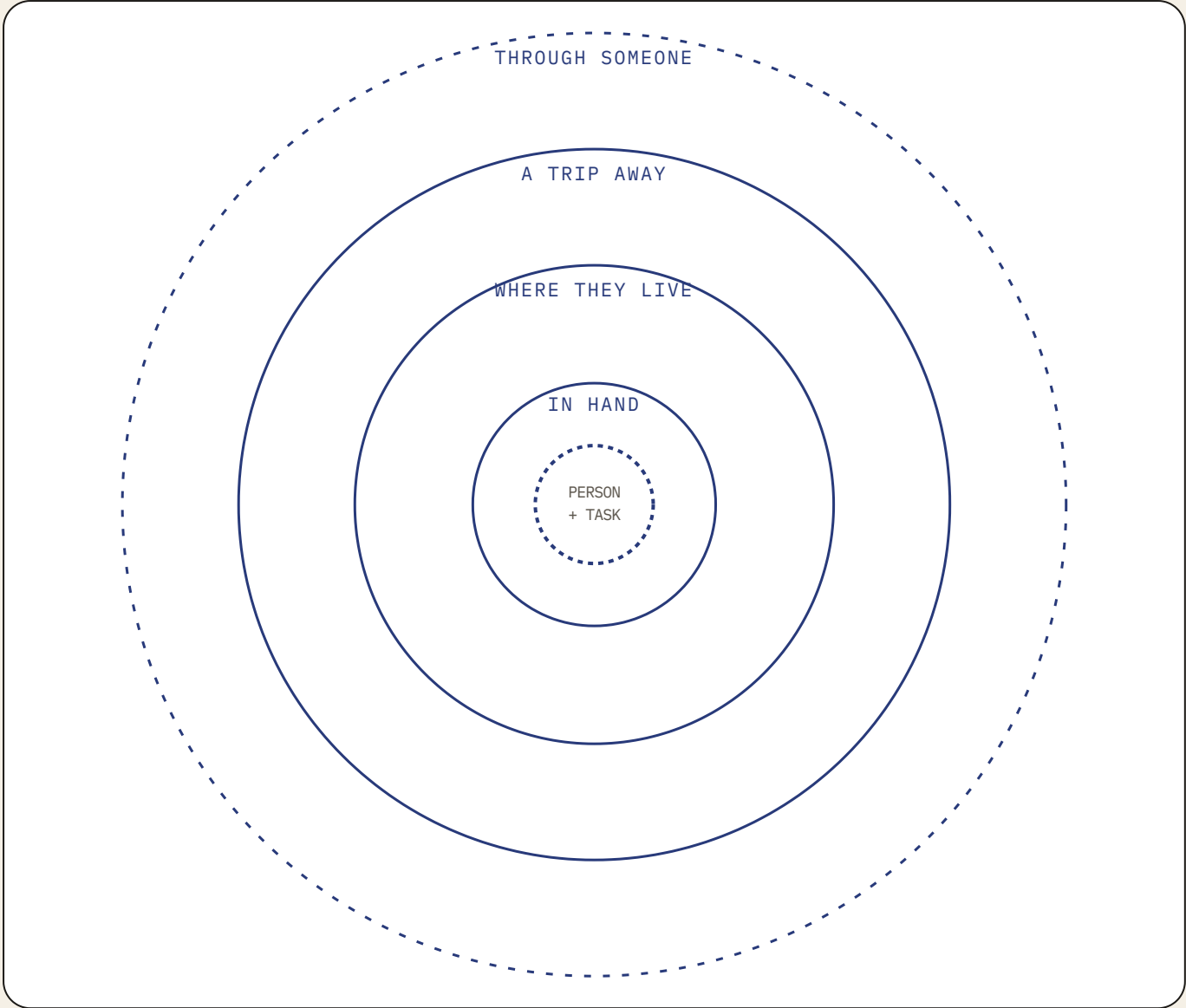
5

Stick the photos next to their tokens.

The Loop

BLANK TEMPLATE

PERSON _____ TASK _____ DATE _____



● Person

■ Thing

▲ Place

P1 Photo

Fill: seen · told · assumed Line = one small task. Owns — · borrows - - · pays for ~. Write the verb on it.

Rings: easy to reach in the centre, hard to reach outside.

Next · Part B, the Ladder →

The Access Ladder

EXAMPLE

← DESIGNER CAN CHANGE MORE

DESIGNER CAN CHANGE LESS →

Key things →	PDF know-how	Father's phone (OTP)	Hostel Wi-Fi	Data pack	Income cert.	Own phone
Priority: designer influence	HIGH	HIGH	MED	MED	LOW	LOW
1 Exists Is it in their world?	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
2 Reachable Can they get to it?	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗ back home	✓
3 Affordable Can they pay once?	—	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
4 Sustainable Does it keep working?	—	✓	✗ drops	✗ runs out	—	✓
5 Theirs Owned or borrowed?	—	✗ his, not hers	shared	✓	—	✓
6 Usable Do they know how?	✗ what's a PDF?	✓	✓	✓	—	✓
7 Permitted Allowed to use it?	—	asks first	✓	✓	—	✓

☐ **Focus first.** Basic access, and the designer can change it.

☐ **Design for next.** Everyday use, and the designer can change it.

☐ **Push for change.** Basic access, but outside the product.

☐ **Keep an eye on.** Everyday use, outside the product.

Meera: her top-left corner is empty, so her team started bottom-left: PDF know-how, the OTP and Wi-Fi. All three are things the product can fix.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Write the key things across the top.

2

Order them by your priority.

3

Go down each column.
✗ at the first "no".

4

Start with one shaded corner.

← HIGHER PRIORITY

LOWER PRIORITY →

Key things → write them in						
Priority: _____						
1 Exists Is it in their world?						
2 Reachable Can they get to it?						
3 Affordable Can they pay once?						
4 Sustainable Does it keep working?						
5 Theirs Owned or borrowed?						
6 Usable Do they know how?						
7 Permitted Allowed to use it?						

- Focus first.** Basic access, high priority.
- Push for change.** Basic access, lower priority.
- Design for next.** Everyday use, high priority.
- Keep an eye on.** Everyday use, lower priority.

Every × you marked can be taken into Tool 2 · Break.

p.4.11 →

Break

Who fills each gap, and what happens when they can't?

⌚ 45–60 MIN 👤 WITH THE PERSON, OR A GROUP EFFORT ●●○ 📍 FIELD OR DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Who the person turns to when something breaks, what gets lost on the way, and the few people everything depends on.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every break has someone who solved it (or X), and each of them has been taken out once.

WHAT IS IT?

It works like Chinese whispers. Take one thing that broke on the Ladder. Ask the person who they turned to, and who that person turned to. Write down what each one told them. Then imagine the most important helper isn't there one day, and see what happens.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Whisper	The chain of people the person asked, in order.
Facts	The few key pieces of information in the original notice or form, like “PDF only”.
Big player	Whoever finally solved the problem.
Cut	Imagining that the big player isn't available.

Play it live

Line up 4–6 people, one per role. The first reads the notice aloud and whispers it on. Compare the last line with the first, then ask one player to step out.

YOU NEED

The Xs from your Ladder (p.4.09), and the person, or their chats and screenshots

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Your big players, and what fails without them

NEXT PAGE **Example • The Whisper →**

The Whisper

EXAMPLE

THE FACTS • FROM THE PORTAL'S NOTICE

Break: PDF know-how

1 PDF only

2 Max 200KB

3 Income certificate

4 Dated after 1 April

WHO SHE ASKED	WHAT THEY TOLD HER	1	2	3	4	ADDS
Roommate SHE TOLD US	"Make it a PDF, there's some app for that."	●	⊘	⊘	⊘	+1 hr
Class WhatsApp SCREENSHOT	"Scan all your docs, last date 30th."	⊘	⊘	●	⊘	+1 day
Senior SHE TOLD US	"Just go to the cybercafé, bhaiya knows."	⊘	⊘	⊘	⊘	+ hours
Cybercafé owner WE VISITED	Solves it for ₹30–50. Picks the file settings himself.	BIG PLAYER				

REPEAT FOR EVERY × • THE BIG PLAYERS

PDF know-how → Cybercafé owner

OTP → Father

Wi-Fi drops → Her data pack

Data runs out → × Nobody

Certificate → Father

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Pick one × from your Ladder.

2

Copy the facts from the original notice.

3

Ask who they asked. Write what each one said.

4

Dot if a fact survived, cross if it was lost.

5

Whoever solved it is the big player.

The Whisper

BLANK TEMPLATE

BREAK FROM YOUR LADDER _____ STEP _____

THE FACTS • COPY THEM FROM THE ORIGINAL NOTICE, FORM OR MESSAGE

A fact is one piece of information the person needed to get it right.

1

2

3

4

WHO THEY ASKED	WHAT THEY WERE TOLD	1	2	3	4	ADDS
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						

BIG PLAYER

Only write what the person tells you, shows you (a chat, a screenshot) or what you see yourself. Fill the dot if the fact survived, cross it if it was lost.

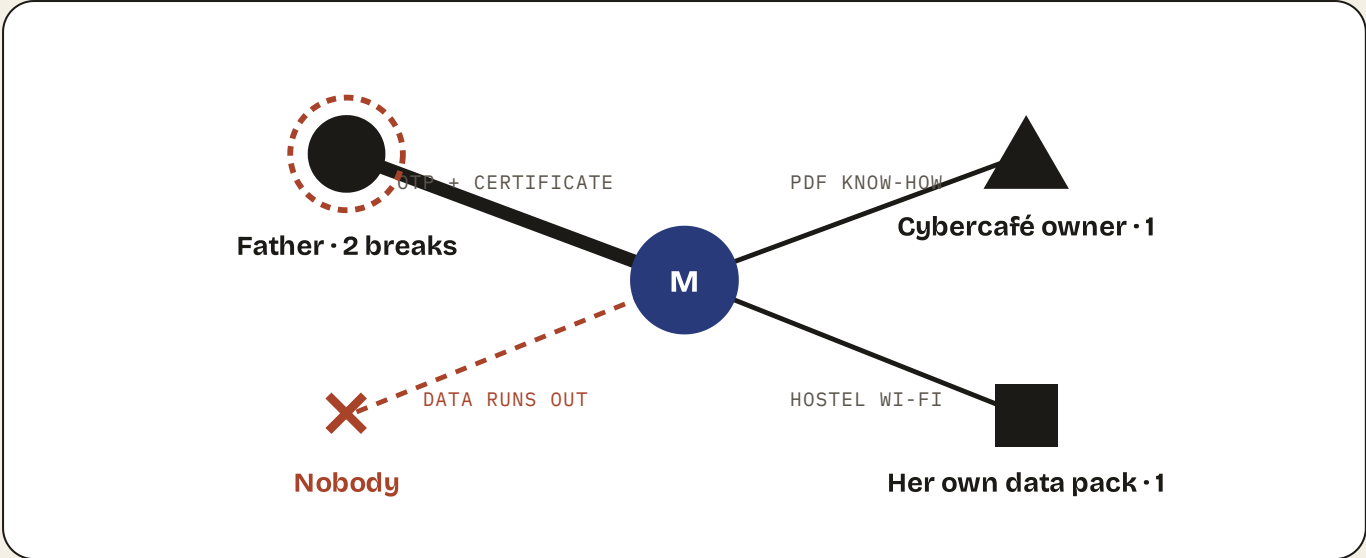
REPEAT FOR EVERY ×

BREAK	HOPS	BIG PLAYER

NEXT **Part B • Big players & the Cut** →

Big players & the Cut

EXAMPLE



✗ Cut: Father isn't available		
DEPENDS ON HIM	FALLBACK	OUTCOME
OTP on his phone	Waits till evening, retries next day	✓ Done, a day late
Trip for the income certificate	No one else in the family can go	✗ Application incomplete

HOW COULD THE PRODUCT SHARE HIS LOAD?

Let Meera choose her own number for the OTP. Let the certificate be requested online, so no one has to travel.

How to use it

1

Put every big player around the person.

2

Draw one line per break they solve.

3

Imagine the busiest one isn't there.

4

Write the fallback, then ✓ or ✗.

5

Ask how the product could help them.

Next page • Blank template →

1 • Map. Write each big player in a circle. Draw one line per break that depends on them.

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

PERSON

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

2 • Cut. Remove one big player at a time. Start with the one with the most lines.

× CUT:

DEPENDS ON THEM	FALLBACK	OUTCOME ✓ / ×

× CUT:

HOW COULD THE PRODUCT SUPPORT THEM, OR SHARE THEIR LOAD?

NEXT **Take the costs and Xs to Tool 3 • Weigh →**

Weigh

What gets compromised first, and how many people live like this?

🕒 30 MIN + DESK TIME

👤 DONE WITH THE PERSON

EFFORT ●●●

📍 FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

What each cost from Tool 2 pushes aside in the person's life, and how common their situation is.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The cards are sorted, the costs are placed, and each finding has a number with a source.

WHAT IS IT?

A card-sorting game you play **with** the person. They lay out everyday needs in the order they'd give them up when money or time is short. You place the costs you found on those cards. Later, at your desk, you back each finding with a statistic.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Need cards	Everyday needs: food, rent, bills, health, education, phone and data, travel...
Compromised first	What they would cut or delay first.
Count card	One finding. The story on the front, a number and its source on the back.

Take care: never ask about income. If family members disagree about the order, offer to sort in private.

YOU NEED

The need cards (p.4.18) and the costs you found in Tool 2

YOU'LL END UP WITH

What each cost pushes aside, and Count cards for Tool 4

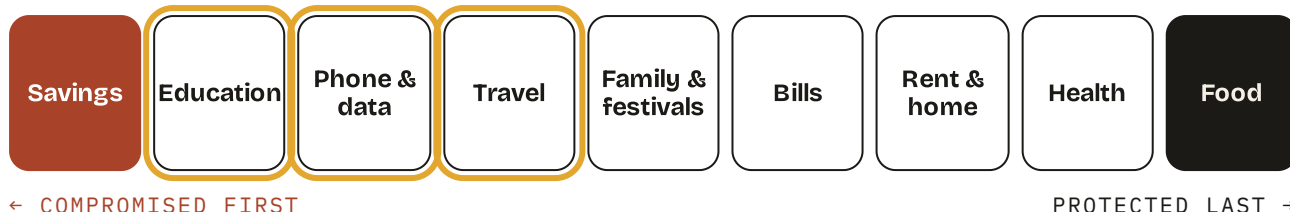
NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's family →**

What gets compromised first?

EXAMPLE

MEERA'S FAMILY

“When money or time is short, what gets compromised first?”



COSTS LAND ON Education (₹50 cybercafé), Phone & data (the lost upload), Travel (the family trip). All near the front of the line.

WHAT MOVES IT A medical bill pushes Health up and Education further down.

COUNT CARD • ONE FINDING

FRONT • THE STORY

“The OTP goes to my father's phone. He's in the field till evening.”

Tool 1: breaks at step 5 • Tool 2: Father is a big player

BACK • THE COUNT

HOW MANY

[Women in (state) with a phone of their own] — NFHS-5

IN THEIR MONEY

₹50 = []% of monthly spending per person — HCES 2022-23

EXPLAINS

Why OTPs so often go through a father's phone.

[Brackets]: fill with the real figure and its source. Never estimate.

How to use it

[Next page • Blank template →](#)
1

Hand over the need cards. They sort.

2

Ask what gets compromised first.

3

Place the costs on the cards.

4

Ask what changes the order.

5

Later, write a Count card.

What gets compromised first?

BLANK TEMPLATE

SORTING STRIP · LAY THE CARDS HERE

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

← COMPROMISED FIRST

PROTECTED LAST →

COSTS LAND ON

WHAT MOVES IT

NEED CARDS · CUT OUT

Food

Rent & home

Bills

Health

Education

Phone & data

Travel

Family & festivals

Savings

Add yours

Translate the cards into the local language, and add a picture to each for people who don't read.

COUNT CARD

FRONT · THE STORY

From Tool __ · step or big player:

BACK · THE COUNT

HOW MANY · SOURCE

IN THEIR MONEY

EXPLAINS

NEXT Take your findings to Tool 4 · Say →

Say

What kind of problem is this, really?

🕒 30 MIN 👤 SOLO OR TEAM EFFORT ●●○ 📍 DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

One clear statement of the problem, including who decided it and who pays for it.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

A teammate who wasn't there can say what kind of problem it is, without seeing your maps.

WHAT IS IT?

A fill-in-the-blanks brief. You finish a few sentences about your biggest break, decide what kind of problem it is, and, if someone passed the cost on, say whose decision that was.

THREE KINDS OF PROBLEM

Oversight

Nobody thought of it.

Offload

Someone chose to pass the cost on to the person.

Constraint

The system doesn't allow otherwise, yet.

YOU NEED

What you found in Tools 1–3, and your Count cards

YOU'LL END UP WITH

A one-page brief to design from

NEXT PAGE **Example • The brief →**

The brief pad

EXAMPLE

The product assumed...	A computer, a scanner, steady internet, one sitting, an OTP on her own phone.
What existed was...	Her own phone, patchy Wi-Fi, prepaid data, no scanner, the certificate back home.
So she...	Asked around until she reached the cybercafé owner, and relied on her father twice.
It cost her...	3 days+ · ₹30–50 + data · a family trip. It ate into Education, the 2nd thing compromised.
This is...	OVERSIGHT no photo-to-PDF, no saving halfway. OFFLOAD proof of income on paper only.
↳ Whose decision was it?	The scheme's rules require a paper certificate from the Tehsildar.
↳ Who benefits · who pays?	The scheme avoids building an online check. Meera and her family pay in time, travel and money.
↳ Was it intentional?	The rule was. The cost to families probably wasn't thought through.
It is true for...	[How many — from the Count cards, with the source]
Prototype next...	Photo-to-PDF in the portal · save and come back · OTP to a number she chooses.

IN ONE LINE

The problem isn't the upload screen. It's three things the portal never helped her get, and one person she can't do without.

How to use it

[Next page · Blank template →](#)
1

Finish each sentence for your biggest break.

2

Pick the kind of problem.

3

If it's an offload, answer the ↳ questions.

4

Add the number. Write it in one line.

5

Test your idea back in Tool 2.

The brief pad

BLANK TEMPLATE

BREAK

PERSON

The product assumed...

What existed was...

So they...

It cost them...

This is...

OVERSIGHT

OFFLOAD

CONSTRAINT

↳ Whose decision was it?

↳ Who benefits · who pays?

↳ Was it intentional?

YES

NO

NOT SURE

It is true for...

Prototype next...

Answer the three ↳ questions only if you picked Offload.

IN ONE LINE

Ask Your Participants

Ask about the task, never about what someone lacks.

TOOL 1 · BUILD

"Show me the last time you did this — from the very start."

TOOL 2 · BREAK

"Who did you ask? And who did they ask?"

TOOL 2 · BREAK

"Do you know anyone who tried and gave up?"

TOOL 3 · WEIGH

"When money is short, what gets compromised first?"

CONSENT · READ ALOUD

"There are no right answers. Skip anything, stop any time. We won't use your name, or anyone's who helped you."

CARE

Never ask income
Helpers by role, not name
Sensitive questions in private
Let them hold the cards
Go back and share what you found

It doesn't end here.

- 1** Test your idea: run it back through the Blame Scale (1.16) or the Cut (4.14).

- 2** Carry the brief into the next component.

- 3** Re-map the same person in six months.

- 4** Write your own tool card — and share it back.

FURTHER READING

Escobar — *Designs for the Pluriverse*

Sen — the capability approach

Max-Neef — *Human Scale Development*

Silverstone & Haddon — domestication of ICTs

Barber & Badre — culturability

Nesta — *DIY Toolkit*

**Make the complexity
visible without
making the
interaction complex.**

OUR FORM PRINCIPLE